

Capstone Project – Professional Certificate in Data Analytics

“Socioeconomic Diversity in UK University Admissions: Does Disadvantage at Entry Compound into Lower Early-Stage Graduate Career Earnings?”

Executive Summary

This analysis examined socioeconomic equity in UK University admissions using the University & Careers Admissions Service (UCAS) POLAR4 and national deprivation index data across 21 board subject disciplines, linked to Department for Education (DfE) graduate earnings outcomes. Three key findings emerge:

1. Medicine & Dentistry has a Q5 to Q1 acceptance share of 4.7, meaning students from the most advantaged backgrounds are nearly five times more likely to be represented than those from the most disadvantaged and it also delivers the highest median graduate earnings of £47,212 at 3YAG, revealing the clearest compounding disadvantage in the dataset
2. Across most subjects, socioeconomic inequity in access has remained broadly stable over 2019 - 2024, suggesting structural barriers have not improved over this period
3. Access equity does not guarantee financial equity. The largest group of subjects are categorised as relatively equitable in terms of access but deliver below-median graduate earnings, leaving disadvantaged students clustered towards the lower-earning pathways even when they do gain entry.

Two recommendations follow this research project to deliver even richer cross-comparative analysis:

1. Extending the earnings analysis up to a scope of 10 years after graduate (10YAG)
2. Incorporating degree apprenticeship data to compare alternative HE pathways

Introduction

The UK higher education sector is under significant scrutiny regarding equity of access (who is accepted to university) and equity of outcomes (what graduates go on to achieve). There is also a growing debate around the value of a traditional degree in a shifting university landscape shaped partly by the rise of degree apprenticeships that offer the alternative opportunity to be paid a salary, alongside a paid-for university experience. In August 2026, the BBC reported that “competition for degree apprenticeships has quadrupled over the past three years.”¹

In-light of these circumstances, I seek to explore three key questions that explore the relationship between access to university and early-stage student outcomes that is rarely examined in a systematic, data-driven way. The three key questions I pose are:

- Which subject areas command the most socioeconomically diverse acceptance shares in UK higher education?
- Do these subjects deliver equitable graduate outcomes?

¹ <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/ckg374p4e24o>

- Does disadvantage at the point of application compound into disadvantage at the point of graduate employment?

Methodology

In this research project, I relied on three publicly available data sources from UCAS and the DfE.

UCAS publish a vast trove of data from their admissions cycles and one of the specific datasets I chose is entitled “UCAS end of cycle 2025 - Subject group (HECoS) POLAR4 acceptances”², which breaks down the data for the UCAS admissions cycles between 2019 - 2024 into subject groups and rates of university participation in a specific area of the UK. I have also used a dataset entitled “UCAS end of cycle 2025 - Subject group (HECoS) IMD2019 NIMDM2017 SIMD2012 2016 2020 WIMD2019 acceptances”³ that breaks down data for the same period by subject groups in addition to national indices for deprivation for England, Scotland, Northern Ireland and Wales.

The subjects are grouped by a common framework known as the Higher Education Classification of Subjects (HECoS) and subsequently, by a Common Aggregation Hierarchy (CAH). I focused on two specific levels of the CAH framework - Level 1 (CAH1) and Level 3 (CAH3). CAH1 is the highest-level aggregation of subject areas that splits courses and subjects into 21 broad groups such as ‘Subjects Allied to Medicine’ or ‘Business & Management’. CAH3 drills down even further into these broad subject areas by splitting these into 166 specific subjects, such as Pharmacology (falling within the CAH1 umbrella subject for ‘Subjects Allied to Medicine’) or Marketing (that falls under the CAH1 subject group of ‘Business & Management’).

The rate of participation in higher education is measured by a methodology developed by the Office for Students (OfS) known as the Participation of Local Areas (POLAR4) that is used as a classification system to group local neighbourhoods according to the proportion of young people who pursue university or higher education pathways at the age of 18 or 19. Quintile 1 (Q1) are areas with the lowest participation rates and Quintile 5 (Q5) measures the highest rates of young people entering higher education.

POLAR4 is not strictly a measure of deprivation but can work as a proxy data source to the explore socioeconomic context of young people in a specific area. Although POLAR4 has limitations as a standalone measure of socioeconomic disadvantage, universities may use POLAR4 quintiles alongside other metrics, such as national indexes of deprivation, to assess a student’s background and make contextualised offers where disadvantage is factored into an offer at the point of university admission. It may also be used to support university widening participation programmes, including outreach, scholarships and bursary opportunities.

UK region-specific indexes of deprivation are a more reliable source of measuring deprivation by combining measurements across a wide range of domains, such as crime and barriers to housing

² <https://www.ucas.com/data-and-analysis/undergraduate-statistics-and-reports/ucas-undergraduate-releases/applicant-releases-for-2025-cycle/2025-cycle-applicant-figures-30-june-deadline>. Refer to the download entitled “UCAS June 2025 deadline 2025 CSVs” in which the original file can be located.

³ This same file can be found in the above link

and services. However, each of the four UK regions has their own rubric for how they assess and add weight to various domains of deprivation. As such, a university applicant in the lowest Q1 of a deprivation index in Scotland may hold a different meaning when compared to a candidate in the same quintile living in England. For instance, Scotland accounts for sub-indicators, such as geographic access metrics, including drive times to a GP, to account for Scotland's unique rural-urban national distribution⁴. Whilst the quintile structure provides a consistent framework for relative comparison within each nation in the context of exploratory data analysis, absolute cross-national equivalence cannot be assumed, as the four indices differ in domains, weightings, geographies and reference years.

It is acknowledged as a limitation of this analysis that there is no meaningful weighted nationwide index of deprivation that can be compared against UCAS admissions data or LEO earning outcomes due to how each region weights their measurements of deprivation, I maintain that if compared alongside POLAR4 quintiles, the indexes can serve as an additional proxy that may reveal a correlation both in-terms of the types of courses candidates access across the different socioeconomic quintiles, as well as their graduate outcomes in-terms of early stage career earnings. As such, I will also be exploring university subject equity through the aggregated lens of the four national deprivation indices – the Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD) for England, Northern Ireland Multiple Deprivation Measure (NIMDM), Scottish Index of Multiple Deprivation (SIMD) and Welsh Index of Multiple Deprivation (WIMD).

In addition to the UCAS datasets that explore the socioeconomic equity of university courses, I will also be exploring the Department for Education (DfE) Longitudinal Educational Outcomes (LEO)⁵ dataset to understand graduate outcomes at CAH3 subject level using the measure of earnings of graduates 3 Years After Graduation (3YAG). I acknowledge that a limitation of measuring such a short period of time does not reflect a longer-term picture of graduate earnings. Indeed, the LEO dataset has the potential to measure up to a 10-year post-graduation earnings spread but extending analysis to a 10 YAG was not feasible due to the timeframe in which the UCAS data was available (2019-2024), as well as the LEO dataset only extending up to 2022. As such, the specific window of time we are cross-measuring in this analysis is between 2019 – 2022. An unintended consequence of this timeframe is that all three retained academic years (2019/20–2021/22) are COVID-affected cohorts, which may suppress graduate employment rates and earnings relative to non-pandemic years. This is acknowledged as a limitation throughout the analysis. Additionally, the LEO dataset does not disaggregate POLAR4 or IMD at the subject level. It does, however, provide median earnings by subject area, enabling a subject-level comparison between graduate earning outcomes. As such, it is not possible to track the earnings outcomes quintiles directly but it is possible to assess whether subjects with inequitable intake profiles – as measured by POLAR4 and IMD quintile representation – deliver stronger or weaker graduate earnings at a CAH1 subject level.

This is achieved by measuring graduate earnings by CAH3 subject codes, which is the key link between our UCAS and LEO datasets. Both datasets use the CAH subject coding system. The

⁴ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Deprivation_index

⁵ <https://explore-education-statistics.service.gov.uk/data-catalogue/data-set/d8bc2906-419e-40ef-ad8e-9b2ccd3997dc>

UCAS dataset contains both CAH1 and CAH3 subject groupings, while the LEO dataset contains CAH3 only. The merge between the two datasets is therefore performed at CAH3 level - the only shared subject dimension. Following the merge, results are aggregated and presented at CAH1 level for visualisation purposes, grouping the 164 CAH3 subjects into 21 broader subject categories for interpretability.

Two CAH3 subjects - Welsh studies and Gaelic studies - were absent from the LEO dataset and therefore excluded from the merged analysis. Both fall within the CAH19 Language and Area Studies group, which remains represented in the merged dataset via its remaining CAH3 subjects.

The primary UCAS POLAR4 dataset contained 60,850 rows across 7 columns prior to cleaning. Both UCAS datasets were filtered to remove aggregate rows (where the POLAR4 or IMD quintile field was coded 'All' or 'Unknown'), to retain only the six admissions cycles from 2019 – 2024, and to filter the 'Main scheme applicant' and 'Main scheme application' fields to 'All'. This was a critical step, as each combination of these dimensions created separate rows for the same accepted applicants, causing an eightfold inflation in totals when summed. Following the cleaning, the POLAR4 dataset was reduced to 4,808 rows across 5 columns, representing one row per CAH3 subject x POLAR4 quintile x Year combination. The total accepted applicants summed across the cleaned dataset was approximately 2.9 million over the six-year period, equivalent to approximately 480,000 per year and consistent with the known UK higher education intake, confirming the validity of the cleaning process. The IMD dataset followed an identical cleaning process, reducing from 224,449 rows to 4,821 rows across 5 columns.

The LEO dataset contains 36,976 rows across 28 columns prior to cleaning. It was filtered to 'First degree' qualification level only, to 1YAG and 3YAG measurement points (excluding 5YAG and 10YAG, as cohorts predating the UCAS data window), and to the three available academic years (2019/20 – 2021/22), reducing the dataset to 1,304 rows across 22 columns. Earnings columns were initially displayed as an object data type due to LEO's suppression code 'c' (applied to cells below a minimum threshold to protect anonymity). These cells were converted to numeric values, with suppressed cells replaced by null values and excluded from the averages.

The primary analytical approach is exploratory data analysis (EDA), using descriptive statistics and visualisation to identify patterns in socioeconomic equity and graduate earnings by subject area. A Q5 to Q1 acceptance ratio was calculated for each CAH1 subject area as a measure of equity, which is a methodology used by the Office for Students (OfS) and acknowledged in university widening participation reporting⁶. Subjects were then mapped against graduate earnings in a quadrant framework to identify those exhibiting compounding disadvantage when compared against the median earnings and median acceptance shares. Finally, a Pearson correlation coefficient was calculated between POLAR4 and IMD Q5 to Q1 ratios to assess the robustness of the findings across the two independent deprivation measures.

⁶ <https://www.suttontrust.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/25-Years-of-University-Access.pdf>

Results

The horizontal bar graph below (Fig. 1) visualises the percentage split of accepted applicants sorted in descending order by the Q1 acceptance share from the most equitable (as measured by Q1 representation) at the top to the least equitable at the bottom. The timeframe encompasses a broader timeframe of 6 years from 2019-2024. If we were to consider a perfectly equitable programme across all quintiles, each quintile would account for a 20% benchmark of the overall acceptances. The chart reveals that for most subjects, Q1 falls significantly below the benchmark while Q5 exceeds it.

There are several interesting observations to note from this graph. For Subjects Allied to Medicine, we note that not only does this subject area have the highest proportion of pupils in the lowest Q1, but we also note a more even spread of quintiles across the board. Notably, we also see Q1 students account for approximately 17% of the acceptances and marginally exceeding the Q5 share of approximately 21% - one of the few subjects where this pattern is observed. Similarly, Education and Teaching also has a relatively even spread of quintiles across the board with the second highest Q1 acceptance share.

Interestingly, in the five lowest subjects in-terms of Q1 representation (Medicine & Dentistry, Mathematical Sciences, Geography, Historical/Philosophical Studies and Combined/General Studies), we can also see this is where the highest proportion of Q5 represented.

In four out of these five subject areas, (Medicine & Dentistry, Geography, Historical & Philosophical Studies and Combined & General Studies), the least deprived Q5 exceeds 40% of the accepted share.

It must be acknowledged that this horizontal chart only shows the acceptance share rather than the acceptance rates. Without the total data on the number of applicants from each quintile, we cannot determine whether lower Q1 representation reflects fewer applicants or lower offer rates. This is an acknowledged limitation of the UCAS data. In addition, it does not tell us about the absolute numbers where there may be some subject cohorts that are larger than others. For instance, there may be more CAH3 subject areas sitting under a particular CAH1 aggregate, which the visualisation does not show due to the limitations of effectively visualising 164 CAH3 subjects.

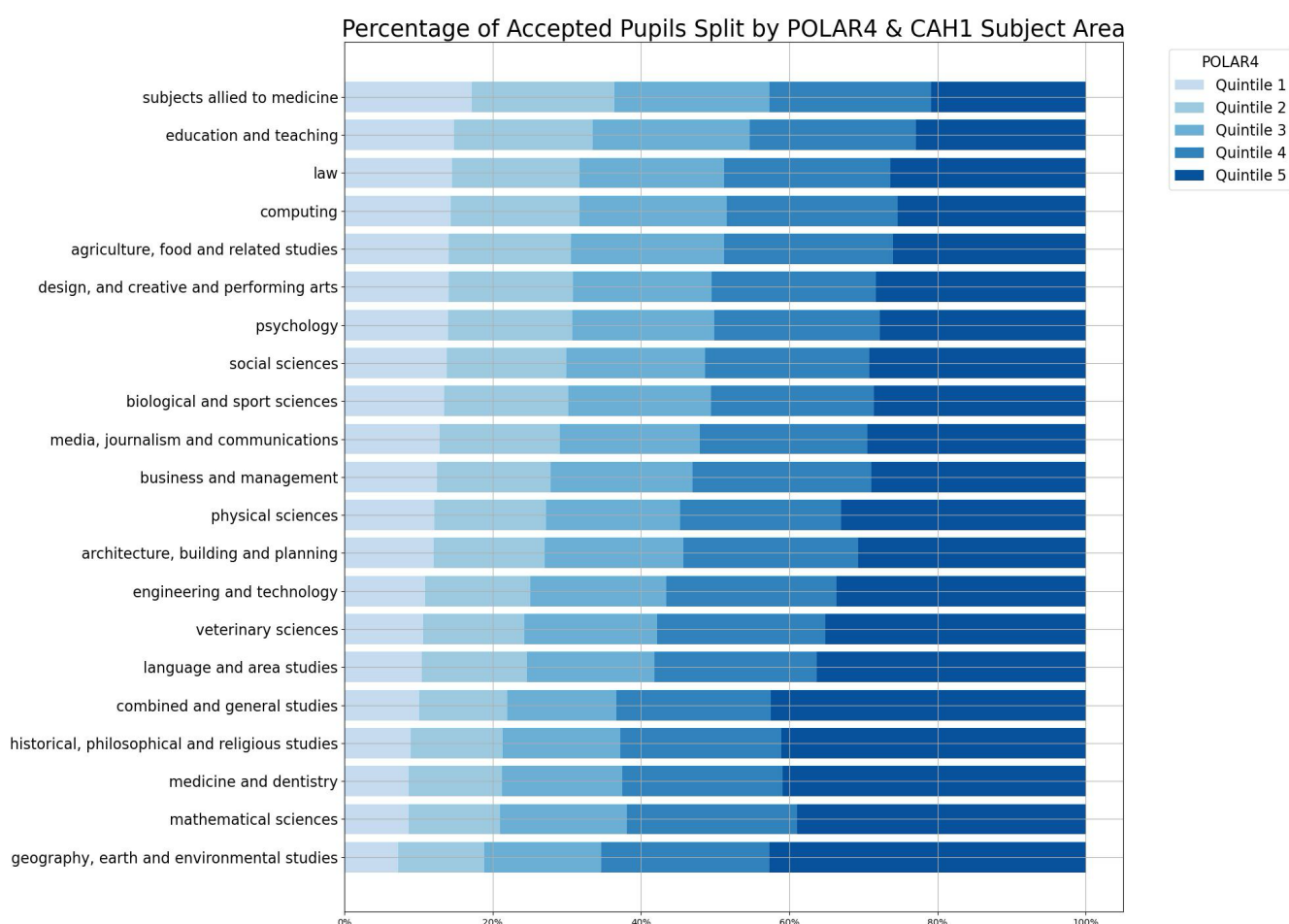


Fig. 1: Percentage share of accepted applicants split by POLAR4 quintiles and CAH1 subject area, ordered in descending order by Q1 percentage share between 2019 – 2024.

The faceted line chart below (Fig. 2) builds on the above dataset to explore how the POLAR4 acceptance share varies per CAH1 subject over the 6-year period from 2019 – 2024. There are several notable observations, namely an inverse relationship with patterns in Q1 and Q5 that appear to move in opposite directions. It is important to note that this analysis is purely descriptive and the inverse movement between quintiles may reflect broader changes in applicant demographics, institutional widening participation initiatives, or external factors, such as COVID-19, and no causal relationship is implied.

For Subjects Allied to Medicine, we see a decline in the percentage share of Q5 between 2021 and 2024. In that same time, however, we see an increase in the Q1 share, amidst the other quintiles remaining at a similar level. We notice a similar pattern for Architecture, Building & Planning, where there is also a drop in the Q5 share from 2021 onwards and an increase in the Q1 share.

Conversely, there are several subjects where we see a decline in the percentage share of Q1 accepted applicants where there is a rise in the Q5 share, for instance Agriculture, Food and Related Studies from between 2022 and 2024, as well as Education & Teaching between 2022 and 2023.

Across most subjects, acceptance shares by quintile remain broadly stable over the 2019-2024 period, suggesting that structural inequities in university programme equitability have not meaningfully changed over this time. However, it also highlights that there is a consistent hierarchy in-terms of subject representation, where acceptance share is broadly aligned with quintile rank indicating that higher quintiles consistently command a greater share of acceptances and in some cases even exceeding 40%, more than double the equitable 20% benchmark. The only two exceptions to this are Subjects Allied to Medicine where Q4 is marginally but consistently higher than Q5, as well as Education and Teaching where Q4 briefly overtook Q5 in 2022.

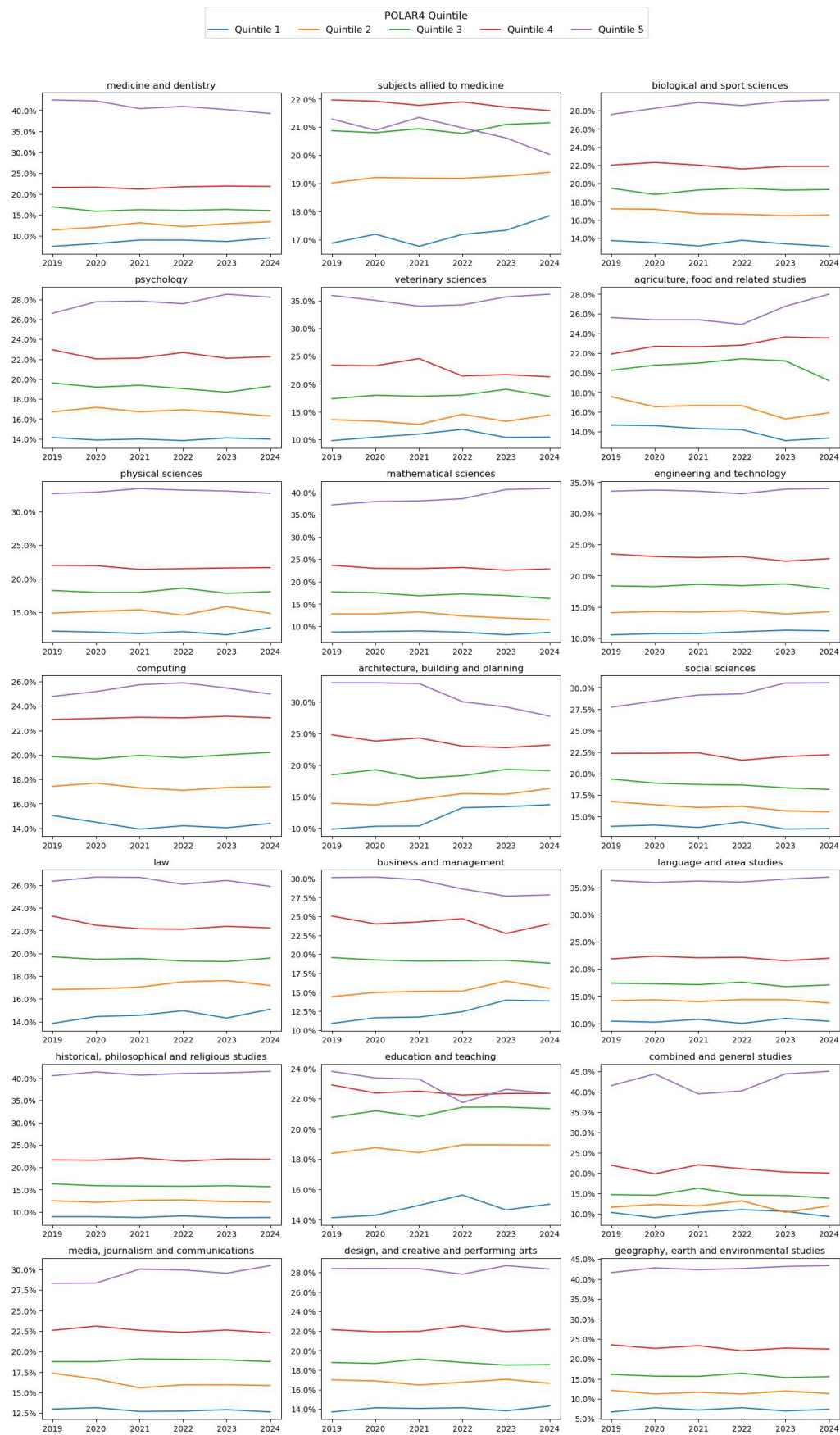


Fig. 2: Timeline of percentage share of accepted applicants split by POLAR4 quintiles and CAH1 subject area between 2019 – 2024.

The scatter plot below (Fig. 3) plots acceptance share by POLAR4 quintiles in the UCAS dataset against median graduate earnings at 3 Years After Graduation (3YAG) for each CAH1 subject from the LEO dataset. Since the LEO dataset provides a single median earnings figure per subject rather than separate figures by POLAR4 quintile, all five quintile dots within a given subject share the same y-axis value. For each of the 21 CAH1 subjects, five dots appear stacked at the same earnings level (one per quintile) spread horizontally across the different acceptance shares. The chart therefore illustrates how a subject's overall earnings outcomes relate to the distribution of its accepted applicants across quintiles, but it cannot show whether disadvantaged graduates earn less than advantaged graduates within the same subject.

While there is no strong linear relationship immediately apparent between acceptance share and earnings across all quintiles, the chart reveals that subjects with higher earnings tend to cluster towards the left of the chart – indicating lower acceptance shares, particularly for Q1. This early-stage analysis motivates the need for a more thorough and direct comparison, explored in Fig. 4 below, which orders subjects by median graduate earnings to examine whether the most financially rewarding subjects also exhibit the greatest socioeconomic inequality as measured by POLAR4 representation.

Graduate Earnings by CAH1 Subject vs. Acceptance Share by POLAR4 Quintile (3 YAG)

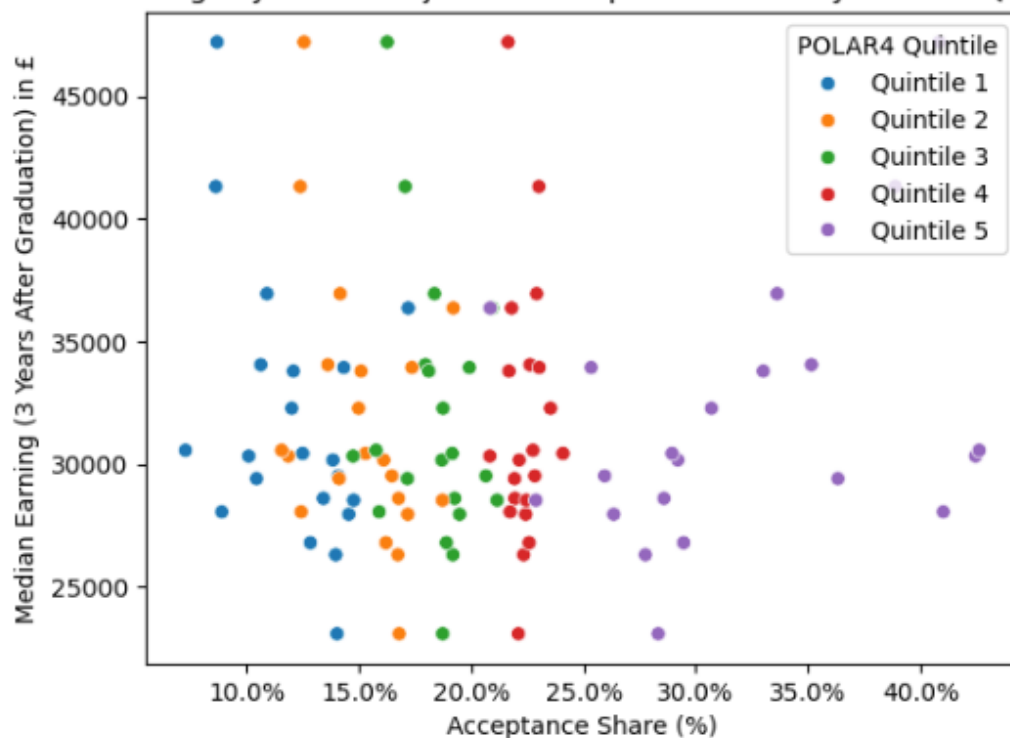


Fig. 3: Scatter plot of POLAR4 quintile acceptance shares against median 3YAG graduate earnings by CAH1 subject area. The vertical clustering reflects that LEO earnings are measured at subject level only and are not aggregated by POLAR4 quintile.

The horizontal bar chart below in Fig. 4 orders the same POLAR4 acceptance share data from Fig. 1 by median 3YAG graduate earnings, revealing whether the subjects dominated by the advantaged Q1 students also deliver the strongest graduate earnings outcomes. The chart tells a

telling sort – the subjects. At the top, Medicine & Dentistry (£42, 212) and Mathematical Sciences (£41, 317) not only command the highest graduate earnings but also display notably thin Q1 representation. Conversely, the subjects at the bottom, including (£23, 078) and Psychology (£26, 300) – show a relatively more even distribution across quintiles, despite their lower earnings.

A clear pattern emerges across the chart. Subjects ordered towards the top by earnings tend to have thinner Q1 representation and significantly higher Q5 representation, whilst subjects lower in the earnings ranking tend to show a more balanced quintile distribution. This suggests a broad relationship between graduate earnings potential and socioeconomic inequity in access. To summarise, it suggests that the higher the earning potential of a subject, the less equitable its intake profile tends to be. This relationship is further explored in Fig. 5.

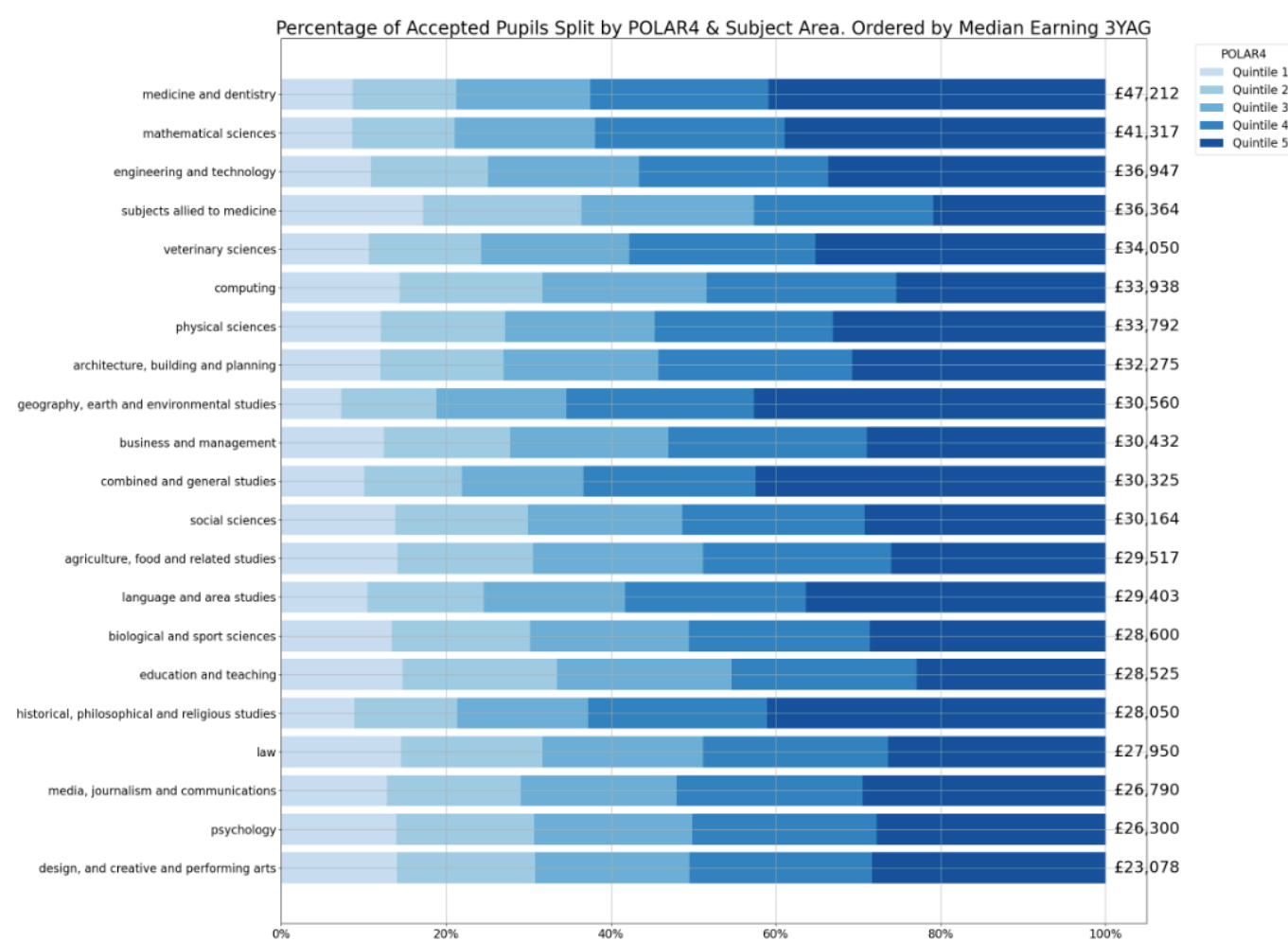


Fig. 4: Percentage share of accepted applicants ordered by median 3YAG earnings. UCAS data 2019-2024; LEO earnings averaged across 2019/20-2021/22 graduation cohorts.

To directly compare the POLAR4 equity ratio on CAH1 courses against median earning outcomes, it would be reasonable to represent this as a scatterplot. In Fig. 5 below, we have plotted the equity ratios as calculated by Q5 divided by Q1 on the x-axis and compared this against the 3YAG median earnings per CAH1 subjects on the y-axis. This ratio of Q5 to Q1 accepted pupils is a widely used measure, acknowledged by universities such as University

College of London (UCL)⁷. The results are mapped into four quadrants representing four key areas: *compounding disadvantage* (inequitable and high earning), *inequitable but low earning*, *equitable but low earning*, as well as *high earning and highly equitable*. The dotted crosshair represents the median Q5 to Q1 ratio (vertical line) and the median earnings (horizontal line) across all 21 CAH1 subjects. This essentially serves as a benchmark against which all other subjects are compared and is used as a basis for dividing the subjects into four quadrants.

There are four key patterns that emerge. Firstly, the scatterplot reveals the subjects that compound disadvantage by being inequitable in-terms of Q5 to Q1 ratio of admitted pupils, whilst also being the highest earning. This shows us that a barrier exists to accessing employment with higher-paid 3YAG opportunities, which include Medicine & Dentistry, Mathematical Sciences and Engineering & Technology. The Q5 to Q1 ratio for Medicine & Dentistry alone is 4.7, meaning that for every place taken up by a student from the most disadvantaged, nearly five are taken up by the most advantaged, and yet it also delivers the highest median graduate earnings 3YAG of £47, 212.

It also reveals several subjects that are inequitable but are also financially rewarding. Interestingly, it highlights a high Q5 to Q1 acceptance ratio for Geography as being close to six Q5 admitted for every single Q1 admission. This is a particularly notable finding, as it suggests that Geography has one of the most extreme access barriers in this dataset, more so than Medicine & Dentistry, and yet it also delivers an earning potential of £30, 560 3YAG, which is only slightly above the median. This suggests that disadvantaged students are therefore being excluded from a subject that does not even deliver above-average financial returns.

Thirdly, it highlights that the largest quadrant contains eight subjects representing the largest proportion of equitable subjects cluster in the low-earning quadrant. In essence, it suggests that access equity does not guarantee financial equity.

Lastly, it highlights a distinct lack of subjects that are both high-earning and high-equity, with only two subjects sitting firmly in this quadrant – Subjects Allied to Medicine and Computing. Subjects Allied to Medicine has the lowest Q5 to Q1 equity ratios of 1.2 (representing the most equitable in-terms of access) whilst also delivering above median earnings of £36, 364 3YAG, suggesting that these pathways may offer a more socioeconomically inclusive route into the medical profession with relatively strong graduate outcomes ranking fourth in-terms of median salary 3YAG.

⁷ <https://www.ucl.ac.uk/widening-participation/widening-participation-groups>

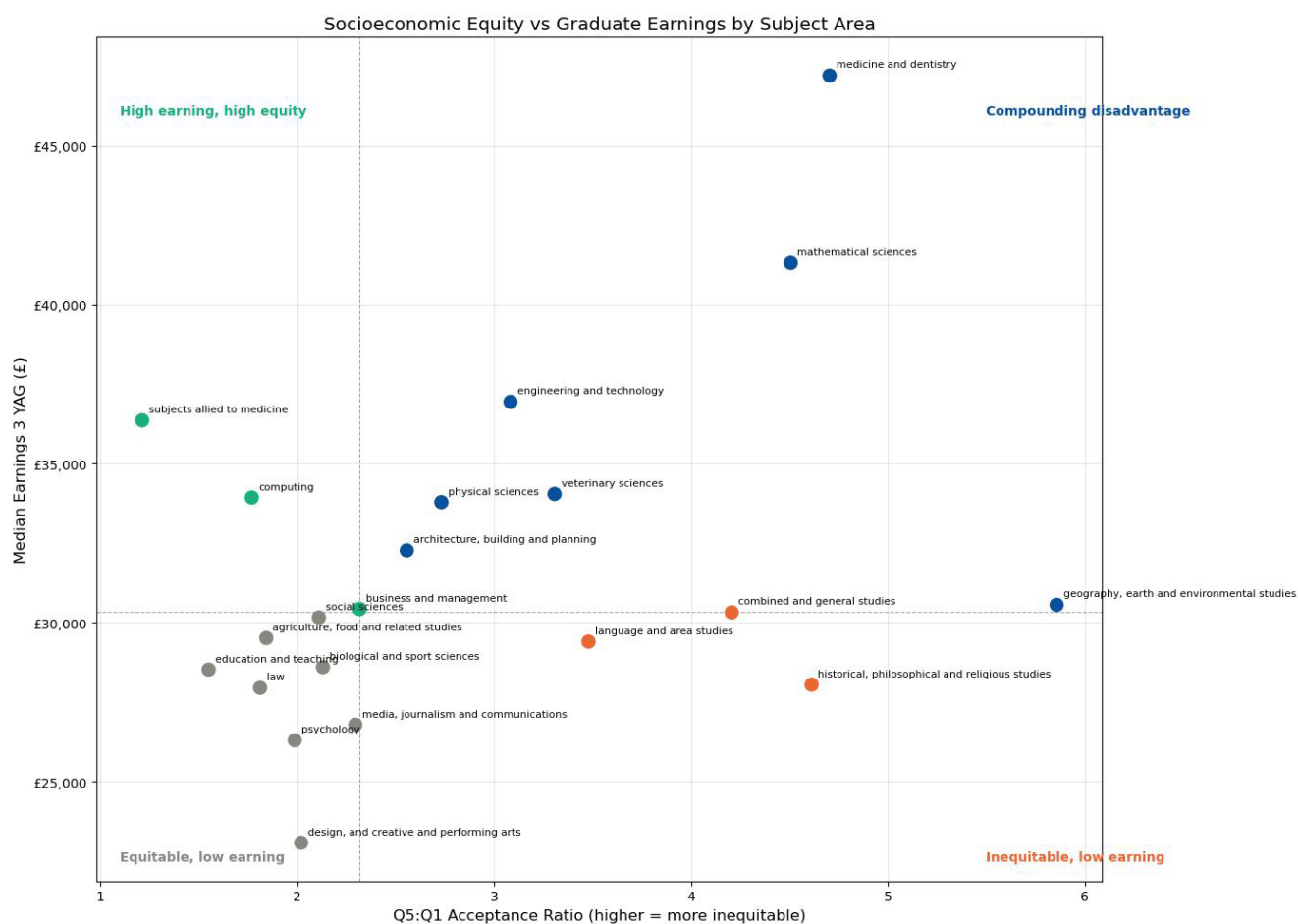


Fig. 5: Quadrant scatterplot representing the median 3YAG earnings for CAH1 subjects and Q5 to Q1 POLAR4 accepted student ratios.

POLAR4 quintiles, which measure young people’s higher education participation rates, are only one way of measuring equity within higher education. According to the Sutton Trust, “POLAR4, an indicator of university participation by local area is currently a key measure of contextual admission in the UK. However, it was not designed to measure socioeconomic disadvantage and is very poorly correlated with low family income.”⁸ As such, it may be helpful to look at disadvantage through the lens of the Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD) alongside POLAR4 to understand whether our findings reflect similar patterns.

In Fig. 6 below, the horizontal bar chart has pooled IMD data available across England, Northern Ireland, Wales and Scotland. It must be highlighted that since each of the four nations have different means by which this index is measured and the factors that contribute to these measures (as outlined in the methodology), the respective nation’s indices are not directly cross-comparable as they differ in domains, weightings and geographies. As England comprises approximately 85% of the applicants⁹, the pooled measure is predominantly an English IMD

⁸ <https://www.suttontrust.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/05/Measuring-Disadvantage-Report.pdf>

⁹ England's share calculated from the raw IMD dataset prior to cleaning, filtering to 'All' for Main scheme applicant and Main scheme application fields, excluding 'All' and 'Unknown' IMD quintile rows, and excluding the aggregate 'All' Domicile row. Total accepted applicants by nation: England 8,706,960; Scotland 796,210; Wales 410,790; Northern Ireland 290,495.

signal. The results should therefore be treated as indicative rather than a precise cross-national deprivation ranking.

The IMD chart broadly replicates the POLAR4 findings in Fig. 1, with Subjects Allied to Medicine remaining the most equitable and Geography the most inequitable under both measures. A notable difference is that Medicine & Dentistry appears more equitable under IMD, with its Q1 share rising from 8.7% (POLAR4) to 15.5% (IMD), reflecting the different dimensions that each measure captures.

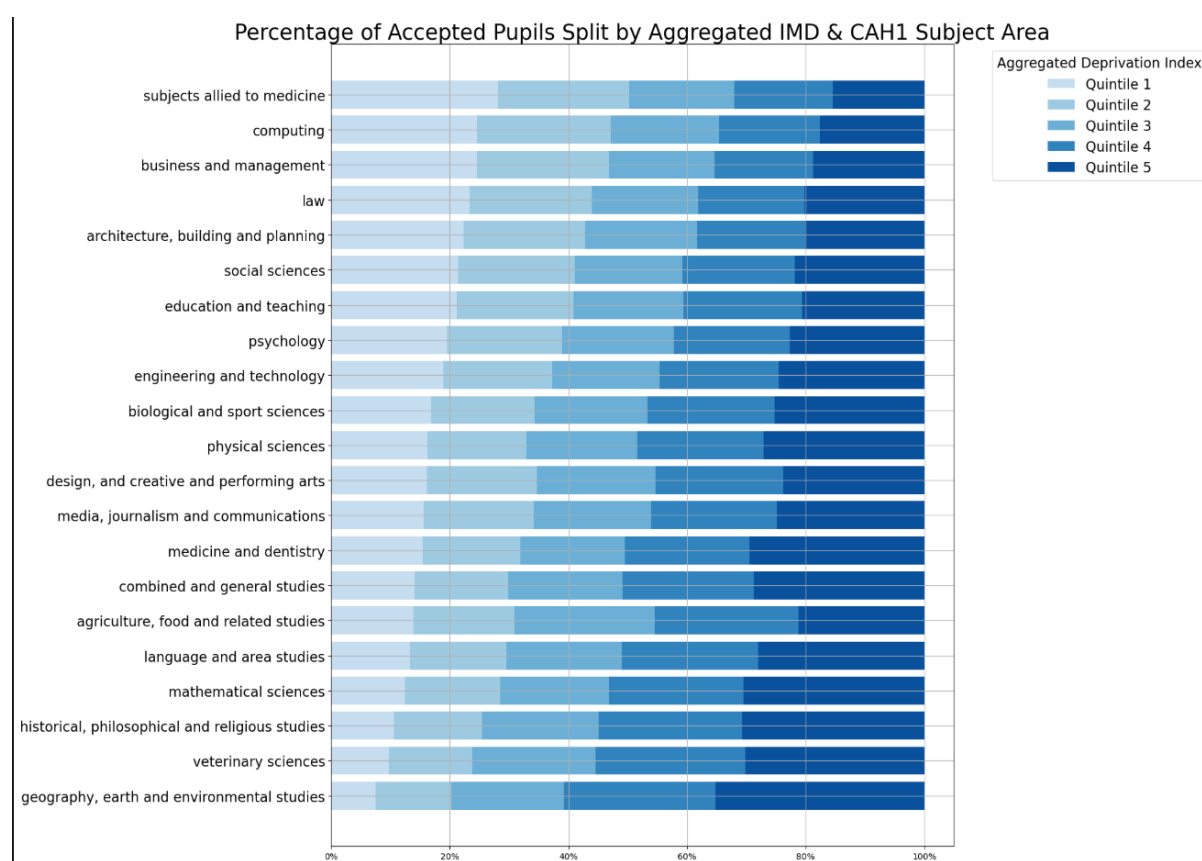


Fig. 6: Percentage share of accepted applicants split by aggregated IMD quintiles across England, Wales, Scotland and Northern Ireland, and CAH1 subject area, ordered in descending order by Q1 percentage share between 2019 – 2024

The IMD scatter quadrant below in Fig. 7 broadly confirms the POLAR4 findings in Fig. 5. Mathematical Sciences remains in the compounding disadvantage quadrant under both measures. The most notable departure is Medicine & Dentistry, which moves into the high earning, high equity quadrant under the aggregated IMD, consistent with the higher Q1 IMD share noted above.

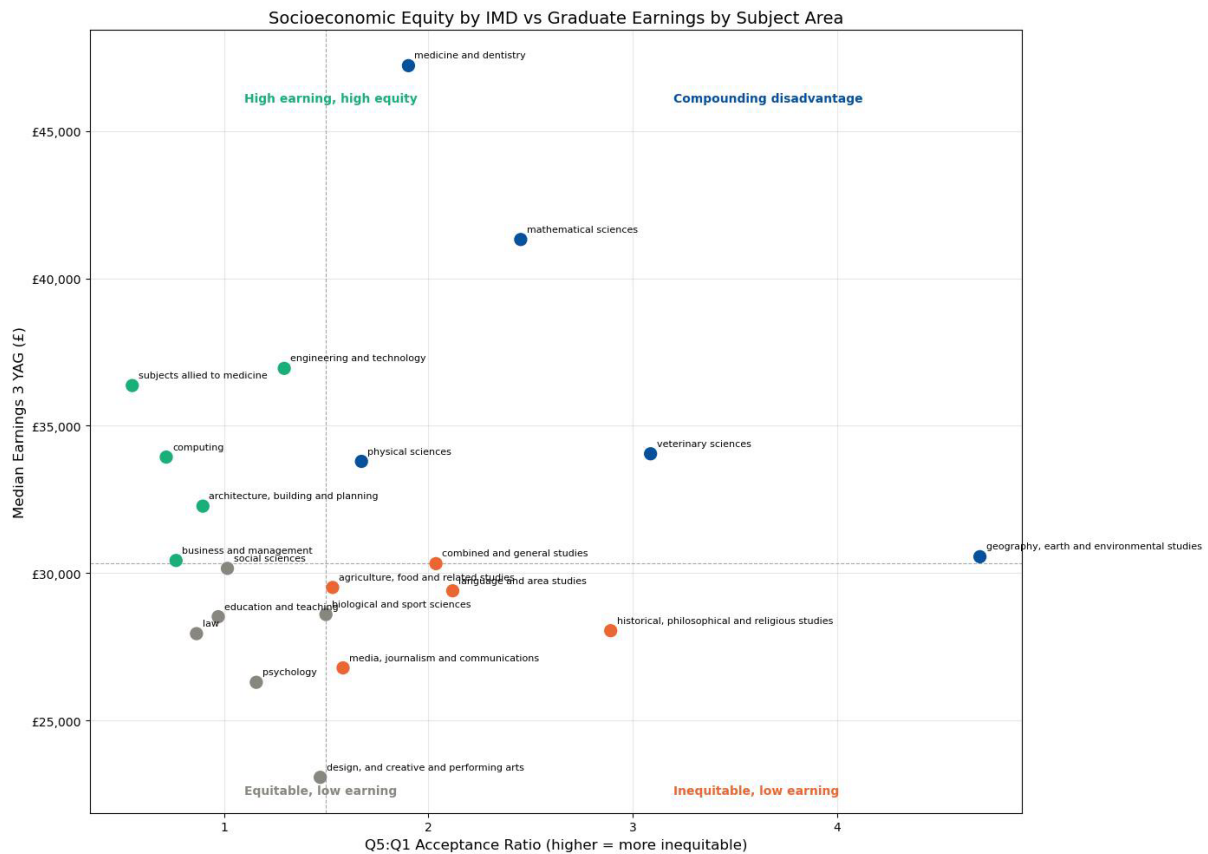


Fig. 7: Quadrant Scatterplot representing the median 3YAG earnings for CAH1 subjects and Q5 to Q1 aggregated UK national IMD accepted student ratios.

Conclusion

This analysis set out to explore three questions: which subjects command the most socioeconomically diverse acceptance shares, whether those subjects deliver equitable graduate outcomes, and whether disadvantage at entry compounds into disadvantage at employment. The findings reveal a complex but consistent picture. Subjects Allied to Medicine and Education & Teaching offer relatively equitable access alongside reasonable graduate earnings. However, the subjects with the most inequitable access – Medicine & Dentistry, Mathematical Sciences and Geography – tend to either be high earning or have extreme access barriers, suggesting that disadvantaged students are disproportionately excluded from the pathways most likely to deliver strong financial outcomes. Meanwhile, the largest cluster of subjects, including Psychology, Law, Design and Media, are relatively accessible but deliver below-median earnings, confirming that access equity does not guarantee financial equity.

To validate these findings across two independent deprivation measures, the POLAR4 Q5 to Q1 equity ratios were compared against the equivalent ratios derived from the pooled UK national indices of deprivation using a Pearson correlation coefficient. A Pearson correlation measures the strength of the linear relationship between two sets of numbers, on a scale of -1 (perfect inverse relationship) to +1 (perfect relationship), with 0 indicating no relationship. The calculated value of $r = 0.85$ indicates a strong agreement between the two measures across all 21

CAH1 subject areas¹⁰. This is to say that subjects identified as inequitable under POLAR4 are broadly aligned as being inequitable under the pooled IMD. This lends confidence to the robustness of the findings and suggests that they are not a coincidence of the specific measurement chosen.

Recommendations

There are two primary recommendations from this analysis. Firstly, future work exploring this area should extend the graduate earnings window beyond 3YAG and ideally to 5YAG and 10YAG to provide a more settled understanding of long-term financial returns by subject, particularly for subjects such as Medicine and Law where career earning trajectories can be steep over an extended timeframe.

Secondly, future analysis should incorporate degree apprenticeship data to compare the socioeconomic profiles of apprenticeship entrants against traditional higher education applicants by subject area. This would be a particularly pertinent question given the rapid growth of this pathway and the significant financial advantage it may offer students from disadvantaged backgrounds who may otherwise find it challenging with the cost associated by a traditional degree.

¹⁰ The Pearson correlation coefficient ($r = 0.85$) was calculated by comparing the Q5:Q1 acceptance ratios across all 21 CAH1 subject areas, where the Q5:Q1 ratio for each subject represents the acceptance share of the most advantaged quintile divided by the acceptance share of the most disadvantaged quintile.